

**MACEDONIA**

Capital city: Skopje
Area: 9,781 sq miles
 (25,333 sq km)
Population: 2,020,000
Official language:
 Macedonian, Albanian
Major religions: Christian
 64%, Muslim 26%,
 other 10%
Government: Democracy
Currency: Denar
Adult literacy rate: 94%
Life expectancy: 73 years

ALBANIA

Capital city: Tirana
Area: 11,100 sq miles
 (28,748 sq km)
Population: 3,200,000
Official language: Albanian
Major religions: Muslim
 70%, Christian 30%
Government: Democracy
Currency: Lek
Adult literacy rate: 99%

MACEDONIA

LANDLOCKED MACEDONIA has been controlled by its larger neighbors for many centuries. Historically linked to Greece, it has more recently been a part of Bulgaria and Yugoslavia. Since the country's independence, however, the greatest threat has come from ethnic tensions between Macedonian Slavs and ethnic Albanians. In this part of the Balkans, the warm climate allows the cultivation of early fruit crops and industrial crops such as rice, cotton, and tobacco. However, its location also means that fuel, machinery, and manufactured goods have to be imported.

EARTHQUAKES

The capital city of Skopje is located where several geological fault lines meet, making it a likely place for earthquakes. In fact, earth tremors in Skopje are frequent, and the city has been destroyed four times in its history. In 1963 an earthquake registering 6.8 on the Richter scale destroyed much of the city. Fortunately, the Turkish area, parts of which date from 1392, survived the destruction.



Freshwater
carp



LAKELAND AREAS

The mountainous area of southwestern Macedonia contains two of Europe's most beautiful freshwater lakes. When the country had more tourists, visitors flocked to Lake Ohrid, and to Lake Prespa, to enjoy the scenery and visit the ancient towns along the shores. Both lakes are teeming with fish, particularly carp, trout, and eels, which are used for local fish dishes. Colonies of pelicans and cormorants also feed on fish from Lake Prespa.



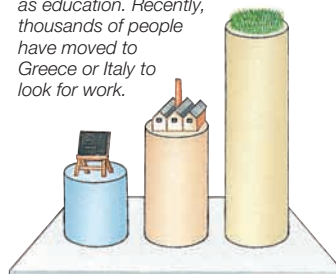
ALBANIA

ONE OF THE POOREST countries in Europe, Albania is mostly rugged mountains. For much of its history, the country was ruled by the Ottoman Turks, who withdrew in 1913 leaving no roads, railroads, or industries. In the last century, Albania was ruled by a fascist king and a communist dictator. Democracy has been hindered by corruption and economic hardships. Violence erupted in 1997 after the collapse of an insurance plan in which many Albanians had invested.



Employment

Jobs are scarce in Albania, and rates of pay are low. Over half of those with jobs work in agriculture, while the rest work in industry or services, such as education. Recently, thousands of people have moved to Greece or Italy to look for work.



COMMUNISM

From 1944–85, Albania was led by the communist leader Enver Hoxha. Under his rule, Albania was cut off from the rest of Europe. The borders with Yugoslavia and Greece were sealed, and no contact with Italy was permitted. All trade after 1960, through ports in Durrës and Vlorë, was with China. The communists developed heavy industry at the expense of agriculture, leaving the country poor and undeveloped. This mural at Tirana Museum represents the people's struggle.

FAMILY LIFE

The family is an important part of Albanian life and, until recently, men were encouraged by the state to father large families. From an early age, Albanians are taught the importance of the promised word, known as *besa*. To break one's word, in a business deal for example, is considered a disgrace.

Find out more

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